Geographies of Wellbeing in Poland (Urban-Rural, Regions, and Cities)

Monday 19th October, 2026 11:43

[proposal after this]

1 changelog

note to myself: srch 'TODO' in this sec

1.1 oct17 met with piotr and incorporating his comments

big/broad items

- The document style requires improvement into more academic.–yes made it more academic, official and uptight TODO still rewrite text more, make uptight/academic
- added at the end WPs/Tasks with KMs

comments/notes responses

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Geographies of Wellbeing in Poland (Urban-Rural, Regions, and Cities)--bad title
geog, not soc
>>> rephrased away from geog to soc as i am going to soc and emphasize better
urb rur; i guess leave geog tit, but in writeup highlight sociology!!! it's
urban and rural sociology added wirth simmel toennies park and fischer; added
that the field is interdisciplinary and cited sociologists :) notably veenhoven
and delhey and bartram

emphasize better urb rur as important and overlooked, and definitely talk about
polska village wies!
>>>added like there is little attention in the us and it has been left
behind add lang from my other cityAgency paper, we hypothetise it may be similar in pol

just using secondary data, not collecting my own data--definitely have to
highlight novelty and contribution!!!
>>>DONE highlighted whats  innovative at the beginning of  hypotheses sec

show exactly how weak is current res and what is new here; cant be incremental,
need to be innovative; have more on problem statement--why is it important!!!
refer to currently going discussion and lit! using secondary data so explicitly
highligh how there is big ass contribution using these data!
>>>done some maybe still TODO more on problem statement--why is it important!!!
background and objectives--czy temat jest warty podjecia!!
>>>done some maybe still TODO

The research gap is not clearly presented.
Data is more described than the conceptual framework. Perhaps a new
conceptualization of urban rural well-being could prove a conceptual novelty.
>>>DONE again added to "hypotheses" section

The specific case of Poland with a context of the Second World War losses and a
particular development after the Second World War during the communist time can
be an interesting reference if the case is taken in a comparative perspective.
>>>WW2/communism another paper!;Â but here we go back to the 90s so post
communist development yes--will do that!; and was thinking to compare to other eur c since 90s and their
development, but gave up on this since this is about pol specifically

Examining spatial and temporal dimensions of well-being dynamics seems
interesting. What are drivers of these dynamics--intermal or external (The EU and
the global economic processes, migration). The data is scarce.
>>>as in previous, no just pol
```

Poland experienced a dramatic increase of economic development measured by
GDP after 1990, but how it translates to well-being ins not clear.
>>>rt again can do 90s till now urb rur in pol v other eur c and gdp gro--and
already just descriptive just for poland is great--there was that easterlin
paper on happiness in economically rapidly growing china--do same for poland here
and add urb-rur :)

I would suggest to include the European comparative perspective as my colleagues
(P.Jabkowski, P.Cichocki) are very well trained and internationally recognised in
harmonisation of surveys data (https://doi.org/10.1093/poq/nfag064). It would be a
good justification of your location in AMU, Faculty of sociology.
>>>yes! added on harmonization
>>>TODO make sure in application form under motivation why AMU

The definition of well-being requires examination.
>>>i added in intro: "Both measures are defined and described in data
section."--there are pretty elaborate descriptions there--do we need more? what
exactly?

Suggested structure:
a) Background, problem description (substantive, theoretical/conceptual,
methodological) and objectives.
b) State of the art [=lit?]
c) Hypotheses, expected progress beyond the state the art.
d) Methods and data
e) Research plan (WPs)
f) Risks
>>>DONE! actually already kind of was done this way, just replaced sec names
[i guess if it doesnt fly can redo more technical like mari did in her grants,
see her gmail "nie do publicznego wgladu"]

NAWA application btw has these:
3.6. Aktywnosci planowane w ramach Projektu: badania, prace rozwojowe, wdrozenia. Prosze opisac:
stan badan; [=lit rev]
cele i zalozenia [=motivation, why this res]
pytania badawcze i hipotezy;
proponowane narzedzia i metody badawcze;
stopien innowacyjnosci; = [lit contribution]
wspolprace z innymi instytucjami naukowymi lub przedsiebiorstwami, w tym
wspolprace miedzynarodowa. = [ebshoy and lina]

have some graphical conceptual model of analysis--piotr says super important
increases chances like 10%
>>>see maris; maybe do fancy tikz--meh forget tiks, but added trancect with smiley faces

wnisoek pisac dla generalists
>>>TODO

US perspective: jest taki kraj polska co ciekawy; ale zmienic perspektyrw!!
>>>ok cut back a bit on that
porownac polske to innych w eruipe i do ameryki poludniowej!
>>>ok done added on lina martinez and lat am

and say while i do have us perspective being here 22 years, this is a strength,
i can compare us urb-rur to polish in this study; and again i am the leader of
the urb rur swb field, again that esseay in PIA sth from ru statements if not
double blind see what katrzyna says
>>>DONE

specific items from comments in pdf

style
>>>made it more uptight/academic

not convincing
>>>added references to sen and seligman

An US view. Simplistic.
>>>ha! yes we are simplistic here :) i cut back

Can be interesting but needs to be engaged in the current literature. Why
this gradient is relevant in EU, Poland, WOrld - needs justification.
>>>yes! done added soc lit; and elaborated on the gradient; and added diagram

It is very descriptive. WHat is the hypohteiss here: is Poland follow a
wider pattern with other Central Europe countries (perhaps a global
pattern?)
>>>no just that growth or shrinkage-->happiness--explained better
and more explicitly

Good, but very descriptive. No breakthrough. A strong need for an
innovative conceptual framework.
>>>DONE added to hypotheses sec

Looks as territorilly embedded. Dat harmonization seems problematic. It
needs to be expained.
>>>added re harmonization

details needed.
>>>added new sec ‘‘Work Plan: Key Milestones’’ and refered the reader to there

Perhaps - discussion with the Catch-up lietarture of the Central EUrope? SOmehow
it is a default underlying concept.
POland compared to Other trasnsition coutries: Latin America? (See
https://books.google.com.fj/books?id=OBvQVhkIvdIC&printsec=frontcover
>>>added new hypothesis to compare with other eur countries; and added new hyopothesis on
social groups: age and education--the educated and younger ones may fare better
in cities v rural; and added a little bit on latin america/colombia too

Perhaps engagement with the energy transformation in Europe which requires
a massive change of consumption, would be important here as the large European
policy altering lifestyles and consequently well-being.
>>>yes!! added and citing my own paper on this!

It requires explanation why citing so old fashioned/obsolete
literature.
>>>ok dropped Fromm

1.2 oct19 incorporated ebshoy comments

I read the proposal carefully, and I have a few general comments:

- A general comment that I have is that the document needs to look more
academic, especially with regard to how it is written and the language used. For
instance, in many cases, there is use of abbreviations whether in the text or in
the footnotes without proper definition/mention of the terms that relate to
these abbreviations.
>>>good to know bc piotr had same comment, so this helps
Yup, I tried to make it more official/academic--let me know what you think!
Esp i tried not necessarily official/uptight but rather super careful about statements meaning;
Feel free to make edits as needed or comment! Usually Rubia helped me on this
but she’s not on this grant--Can you help me out here and edit it? can just say
edits in email or comment on pdf

I think that we need to start the background section with something broader
about human wellbeing, not something very specific about the outcome of interest
in this project. I think the first one or two paragraphs should be more about
human wellbeing in general.
>>>Ok, moved 2 last para to the beginning

- In the background section on page 3, you write that the field is
interdisciplinary with key contributions from sociology. I feel that there could
be citations from other fields especially geography, and urban studies since the
project is weighing heavily on this relationship between place and wellbeing. I
saw the notes you added for yourself on whether the focus should be on geography
or sociology. I think if you say that the study of well being is
interdisciplinary, then we should be open with regard to the fields that inform
the research.
>>>I see your point and agree, but I’m applying to do the project in sociology
dept, so need to tie to sociology, otherwise reviewers may say it doesn’t fit
into the dept

- I think that reviewers could get a feeling that we are imposing our
conventions on reality while they are reading theÂ proposal. For instance, in
page 4 you write that "there may be similar pattern in poland and it may work to
decrease rural SWB that otherwiseÂ should be more than urban".Â Reviewers might
question such statement since we kind of impose our perception on reality by
saying that subjective wellbeing should be higher in rural areas compared to
urban centers.
>>>good points! rephrazed to to hypotetise;
btw also note that grants are different from papers--here we’re business-like
trying to sell and market; not enlighten

In another instance in the text, in page 6 you write the following "H2b Across
regions correlation between objective quality of life measures such as income
with SWB measures will be moderate only at < 0,5". I think reviewers might
question this hypothesis since it is very specific and you even specify the
magnitude of correlation.Â
>>>Ok good point commented that out [and its a hypothesis, so im not imposing
anything on reality just hypothesising]

In the conceptual framework section, you discuss points that relate more to
methods and not theoretical/conceptual grounding of the work. For instance, on
page 6 you write that "Finally, our innovative conceptual framework includes

using large multiple datasets (see next data section) at multiple levels: urban-rural (and over time since the 90s), voivodeship (NUTS2), and city." Here we are conflating between the research design and the conceptual framework of the study. Also, you describe the conceptual framework as innovative, but technically we are here referring to the research design as being innovative.
>>>ok, changed

Furthermore, you start the conceptual framework section with referring to classic theory without really explicating how the study will be framed based on these classic theories. So, I think this section needs more elaboration on how we conceptualize the research in light of these classic theories, including works of Wirth, Simmel, Fischer, and others.Â Â
>>>yes! elaborated! let me know what you think!

- You say in many parts of the proposal that there are no studies on the urban-rural gradient of SWB in the Polish case, but then you discuss a few papers that actually investigate this issue. So, I think these claims need to be reconsidered because they relate directly to the claims on the contributions of the project itself.Â Â
>>>Ok i rephrased to multidimensional wellbeing studies with elaborated urban-rural gradient, but only found 1 or 2 such instances, let me know if anywhere else you see anything

- In the "Significance, Policy, and Practice" section, you detail the outcomes and deliverables of the project saying that the project will produce 4 peer-reviewed articles. You also mention that the findings will be disseminated to policy makers and the public through public lectures, popular press, and social media. But given that this project is funded through the government, I believe that one of the deliverables should be policy papers and briefs presented to the government agencies that could be interested in the findings of such a project.
>>>No, it's not a requirement, the goal of the program is not that

I have a question. How competitive is this grant? Do you think there is a good chance that we will get it?
>>>25% chance, so let's do a good job and we will get it!

Also, I found two European datasets that have very interesting questions, especially questions that pertain to mental wellbeing as well as SWB: the European working conditions survey and the European Quality of Life Survey. I think Poland is included. So, maybe we can also include these surveys into the proposal. I have downloaded the datasets. They are very rich surveys. I think you worked on the European Quality of Life survey if I am not wrong. So, maybe we could include them since they include the mental wellbeing index, and this could be an interesting outcome that the government of Poland might be interested in especially that the index has been devised by an international organization, the World Health Organization and it is actually titled the WHO mental wellbeing index (it is an index of 5 questions).
>>>We can always add it later, we already have like 5 datasets, and ess has special modules like I guess wave 6 that have like over 20 wellbeing items

2 Background, Problem Description, and Objectives

Earlier there was a need economic growth focus in Poland, now there is a need for wellbeing focus. Polish PCGDP PPP[1] is very close to that of Japan, and Polish minimum wage of 31 PLN or 8.15 USD (as of 2026) is higher than the US minimum wage at 7.25 USD. As Poland has experienced economic miracle over past several years,[2] now it is time to focus on wellbeing. Wellbeing is increasingly relevant over economic/survival basics such as income and employment. For visualization of the changing values from survival to wellbeing along with the economic growth see figure 1.

[1]Per Capita Gross Domestic Product Purchasing Power Parity adjusted.
[2]For instance Warsaw Stock Market Index (WIG) has increased about 120% over past 5 years.

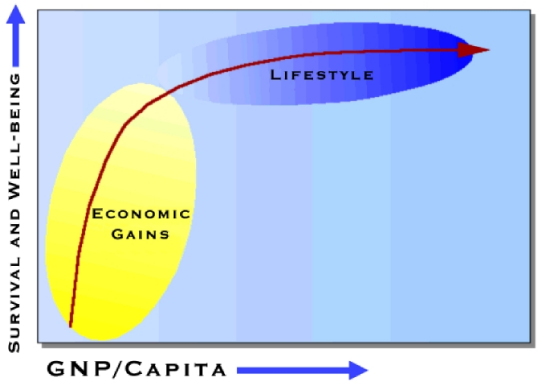


Figure 1: From survival to wellbeing as economic growth increases (Inglehart 1997). As Polish GNP/capita has increased sharply over the recent years, the scholarly (and public) focus can and should shift from survival to wellbeing, and from economic gains to lifestyle.

Leading scholars advocate such change in focus from survival to flourishing. Seligman (Seligman 2004, Diener and Seligman 2004) led change in psychology that traditionally used to focus on the negative side of human condition such as loneliness, anxiety, and depression–where psychologists have been trying to bring people from failure to normal. He pointed out that we should now focus on how to go from normal to flourishing. Amartya Sen led change in economics–he pointed out the limits of economic metrics such as income and production, and proposed that the time has come to focus on wellbeing (Stiglitz et al. 2009, Sen 2000).

The proposed study's outcome of interest is multidimensional human subjective wellbeing (SWB) or flourishing. Two key dimensions are happiness or life satisfaction[3] and freedom (agency/autonomy),[4] see data section.

The proposed project fits under the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs): #3 "Ensure healthy lives and promote well-being for all at all ages." Happiness is now recognized as a development goal in addition to GDP–the UN has passed resolution A/RES/65/309: "Happiness: towards a holistic approach to development" stating that "the pursuit of happiness is a fundamental human goal" and "recognizing that the gross domestic product indicator [GDP] by nature was not designed to and does not adequately reflect the happiness and well-being of people."[5]

Freedom (agency/autonomy) is a human right as stated by the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (art. 26, 29): "freedom for the realization of one's human potential." Freedom is an end-in-itself, as recognized by Amartya Sen (2000).

There is a new geography of wellbeing field (e.g., Ballas and Dorling 2013). The field is interdisciplinary with key contributions from sociology such as Ruut Veenhoven (Brulé and Veenhoven 2015, Veenhoven 1994, 2000b), Jan Delhey (Delhey and Newton 2005, 2003, Delhey and Dragolov 2016, Delhey et al. 2002, Alber et al. 2005) and David Bartram (Bartram 2013a, 2011, Hendriks and Bartram 2019, Bartram 2013b). The field has mostly international focus across countries, with only few recent studies focusing on specific countries (see next section). Poland still lacks a comprehensive and dedicated multidimensionsal wellbeing study using a proper multistep urban-rural gradient across space, time, and social groups. The proposed study aims to fill this gap.

3 State of The Art: Urban-Rural, Regions, and Cities

Poland is a diverse country in terms of its urban-rural, regional, and city geographies. Urban-rural is not a binary, but a gradient–we will use several steps to capture this gradient. Most scholars just use a binary, but wellbeing raises non-linearly from urban to rural

[3]We use the terms interchangeably as is the usual practice in the social indicators literature, but specifically we mean global cognitive evaluation of life as whole rather than momentary and fleeing affective happiness.

[4]Specifically we mean so called `freedom to`, not `freedom from` (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014a). Poles are `free from`: live in a free country, have no coercion, and are free from restrictions and impediments. But are they `free to`? Are Poles actually able to choose, control and direct one's own life (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2015)?

[5]See `https://docs.un.org/en/A/RES/65/309`. Also see report promoting wellbeing as a human development goal by Nobel prize laureates Sen and Stiglitz (Stiglitz et al. 2009).

intensifying at population size of below several hundred thousand (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017).

Urban-rural gradient matters a great deal, more than most scholars realize. Indeed, it is difficult to overestimate its importance–the key point is that urbanicity is not only a built environment, but a way of life (Wirth 1938). Classic sociologists were aware of the profound impact or urbanism, but modern empirical studies in this area do not properly ground their work in theory, and as a result do not measure the constructs properly. The theoretical foundation of urban-rural wellbeing field is sociological. Not only as urbanism as a way of life (Wirth 1938), but also metropolis and mental life (Simmel 1903), and Gemeinschaft and Gesellschaft (Tönnies [1887] 2002). While there is a more recent empirical tradition in American urban sociology in study of urban wellbeing notably by Claude Fischer, this line of research has largely been discontinued after 2000 (Fischer 1999, 1995, 1982, 1981, Fischer and Merton 1976, Fischer 1975, 1973, 1972). The proposed study aims to use the classic sociological theory with recent data to conduct a study in Poland.

Weckroth and Kemppainen (2021) is a closely related study to our proposed study–they analyze SWB by urban-rural using ESS (European Social Survey) in Europe–we will also use ESS among other datasets, but focus on Poland and add more recent waves and more wellbeing indicators. Knies (2026) is another close ESS study[6] –it uses multiple indicators, but only wave 6 and like other research does not focus on Poland. There are no studies on urban-rural freedom gradient, not just in Poland but anywhere–ours is the first.[7]

From another perspective, there is literature on "left behind ruralities" (Ulrich-Schad and Duncan 2021), "places that don't matter." (Rodríguez-Pose 2018)Rurality in the developed world is increasingly a periphery, loosing power and voice v urban centrality, being abandoned and disrespected–there is rural discontent, resentment, and shame. See superb US accounts in Hanson (2015) and Fuller (2017). Wy hypothesize a similar pattern in Poland and it may work to decrease rural SWB that otherwise is hypothetised to be higher than urban. Next we turn to regions.

Regions are an useful level of analysis as there are great differences within countries and across regions, and Poland is no exception. There are life satisfaction studies across regions (e.g., Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011, Ballas and Rijnks 2023, Ziogas et al. 2023, 2020), but no study focuses on Poland. Similarly, quality of life and wellbeing studies across regions and cities focus on cross-country patterns, not Poland, and tend to use older datasets (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2019, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2013). Poland has 16 voivodeships, so called NUTS2 level regions.[8] At NUTS2 level we will investigate geographic clustering and the relationship between objective development measures such as income and subjective measures (SWB).

There are also opposite population dynamics at NUTS2 level, for instance, Mazovia (where Warsaw is located) has been growing, but most other regions have been stable or shrinking. We will investigate the effect of population change on wellbeing. The hypothesis is that population growth predicts greater wellbeing, and population shrinkage predict lower wellbeing (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024), but there has been no such study in Poland. Population growth signifies bright outlook, and decline signifies difficult times coming. The theory that may explain the mechanism between population change and SWB is the so-called "tunnel effect." Humans tend to think that whatever is happening around, whether things are getting better or worse, will eventually happen to them as well.[9]

[6]And there are 2 more ESS studies: Ivanovic et al. (2022) is an urban-rural study, but again only 2 waves and no focus on Poland. Vaznonienė and Jarašiūnaitė-Fedosejeva (2019) is interesting ESS study in a sense that it does focus on one country and discusses country specific intricacies like us, but it is Lithuania. Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente (2021) is a major recent study using WVS (World Values Survey), but as most research it focuses on cross-country patterns, not Poland.

[7]Yamagishi et al. (2012) studies urban-rural freedom but in very different way from us–they show that urbanites are more likely to chose extravagant pens than rural folks. We will study freedom for urban-rural and regions (we do not have freedom variable for specific cities).

[8]Voivodeships=NUTS2, except Mazowieckie (the Warsaw region)–1 single voivodeship, but 2 NUTS2: Warsaw Metropolitan and Mazovian Region; so total of 17 NUTS2 regions.

[9]

> Suppose that I drive through a two-lane tunnel, both lanes going in the same direction, and run into a serious traffic jam. No car moves in either lane as far as I can see (which is not very far). I am in the left lane and feel dejected. After a while the cars in the right lane begin to move. Naturally my spirits lift considerably, for I know the jam has been broken and that my lane's turn to move will surely come at any moment now. Even though I still sit still, I feel much better off than before because of the expectation that I shall soon be on the move (Hirschman, quoted in Ravallion and Lokshin 2000, p. 88).

Finally, we turn to cities–we have data representative of Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw with domain satisfactions (life, place, personal, and financial), and various quality of life indicators regarding amenities (e.g., public goods and services such as parks) and disamenities (e.g., community problems such as crime). We will investigate these across the cities. Specifically, large Warsaw (and perhaps Cracow) is likely to differ from small Bialystok. Warsaw stands out as not only the largest city, but also possibly a primate city, disproportionately larger and more influential than any other city.[10]

Last but not least, there are several related Polish studies in smaller local journals that are worth mentioning as they are mostly about Poland specifically–again, the international literature does not focus on Poland. Cichocki and Jabkowski (2009)is a hidden gem–our study will be similar, but using more and newer data, controlling for relevant predictors of SWB, and situating the study in the international literature. Sompolska-Rzechuła and Kurdyś-Kujawska (2020) is quite similar, but uses different data: Polish Social Diagnosis dataset and does not control for SWB predictors. Vaznonienė and Wojewódzka-Wiewiórska (2021) uses ESS and studies urban-rural SWB like us, but focuses on Lithuania v Poland, and uses waves 4 and 9 only and 3 urbanicity categories only, and does not control for SWB predictors. Wojewódzka-Wiewiórska and Dudek (2023) is the same, just uses waves 2 and 8. Tobiasz-Adamczyk and Zawisza (2017) does the analyses across the regions and urban-rural, but their sample is elderly and the study is about health only. Stangierska et al. (2022) studies quality of life across green v not green urban areas, but only across Warsaw neighborhoods, and the sample size is small at 381 persons. Sompolska-Rzechuła and Kurdyś-Kujawska (2021) uses Polish Social Diagnosis and studies urban-rural SWB–but separately: predictors of SWB in urban separately from predictors of SWB in rural. Overall, while there are studies focusing on Poland, like our proposed study, they have important limitations as summarized above, notably failing to adjust SWB estimates with relevant controls, a critical oversight because the gradient often arises only with proper controls (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Valente 2021).[11] Hence, we know little about wellbeing geographies in Poland–we turn to our study.

4 Innovative Conceptual Framework And Hypotheses–Progress Beyond the State the Art

Principal Investigator (PI), Adam Okulicz-Kozaryn, has coined the term "urban-rural happiness gradient" in his early work (Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2011). PI is the leader of the field and the at the forefront of the urban-rural happiness debate,[12] having extensive experience in leading such studies in the US (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2017, Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2024, Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2009), India (Deb and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2023), Egypt (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), and Colombia (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026), and thus best positioned to carry out such a study in his home country, Poland.

It will be the first such study in Poland. Our innovative conceptual framework rests on going back to the classic sociologists of the 19th and 20th century such as Toennies, Wirth, Simmel, and Fischer. Careful reading of the classics will motivate meaurement: choice of variables, indices (constructed using factor analysis), coding, and modeling (e.g., mediation v moderation). The classic theorists put forward research theories and theses that could not be properly tested at the time due to lack of data and computing. We ground our research better in classic theory, which allows us to pose research questions and use measures and models overlooked by the contemporary research, especially in Poland. The innovative research design includes elaborated urban-rural gradient measurement. We will use 5-8 bins depending on the survey to measure urban-rural gradient, a critical improvement over usual binary or ternary urban-rural measurement in the literature. Urban-rural wellbeing gradient is visualized in figure 2.

[10] At $> 3m$ Warsaw metro is larger than Katowice metro at about 2.5m and third Karkow metro at 1.5m. While Katowice metro is not half or less of Warsaw metro as "the law of the primate city" would indicate (see discussion in Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2012), it is only due to the location of Katowice in regional industrial cluster (Gornoslaski Okreg Przemyslowy (GOP)), Katowice city itself is much smaller than Warsaw at 0.28m v 1.9m. Warsaw is not such clear a primate like Cairo (Mikhaeil et al. 2024), but it probably is similar in its primate status to Bogota (Okulicz-Kozaryn et al. 2026).

[11] And there are several studies that differ from the above. Churski and Perdał (2022) has very fine geographical resolution of 380 units across Poland, but they do not study SWB, only the related objective indicators such as jobs. Weziak-Bialowolska et al. (2025) is one of the very many of the studies co-authored with VanderWeele, this time in Poland, but there is no geography in the study. Wkeziak-Bialowolska (2016) uses the same flash barometer 366 that we will use, but does not focus on Poland and instead on all European cities.

[12] For instance see the discussion in framing essay IV in Pia Heike Johansen and Fisker (2022).

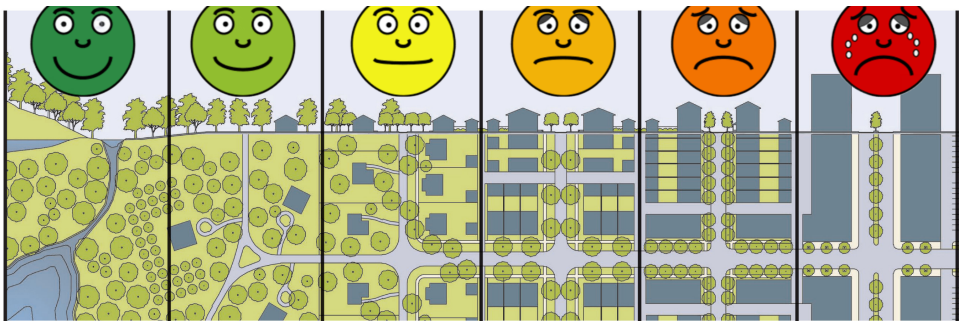


Figure 2: From right to left: Urban-rural gradient visualization with transect diagrams symbolizing urban-rural environments and corresponding frownie to smiley emojis symbolizing wellbeing gradient. From urban to rural there is increasing nature, biodiversity and hypothesized wellbeing. Source: Authors. The transect diagram for urbanicity is by Duany Plater-Zyberk & Company `https://transect.org/rural_img.html`

Another innovation is a more extensive measurement of wellbeing. We will use a battery of survey items to capture multidimensional wellbeing measuring not only life satisfaction as most literature does, but also domain satisfactions, functionings, agency, and vitality. Combining multi-step urban-rural wellbeing gradient with multidimensional measurement of wellbeing and focus on Poland, our study is the first of its kind–nobody to date has used such a research design. Finally, our innovative research design includes using large multiple datasets (see next data section) at multiple levels: urban-rural (and over time since the 90s), voivodeship (NUTS2), and city. The proposed research will test the following hypotheses to produce new knowledge (academic value), which has notable policy and practical innovative uses–see section "Significance, Policy, and Practice."

H_1 Cities have lower multidimensional Subjective Wellbeing (SWB) than rural areas, with the largest drop occurring for the largest places. [WVS, ESS, FB539][13]

H_1a Certain social groups such as working-age adults and upper social classes have higher SWB in cities v rural areas. [WVS, ESS]

H_1b Over time, from 1989 to 2012 (WVS), and from 2002 to 2025 (EVS), the SWB gap between cities and rural places has increased. [WVS,EVS]

H_2 More remote, less populated, and lower density regions have higher SWB than more central, more populated and higher density regions. [ESS, FB539]

H_2a Regions that experienced population growth will have higher SWB than flat or shrinking regions. [ESS, FB539]

H_2b Across regions correlation between objective quality of life measures such as income with SWB measures will be moderate only, thus revealing inadequacy of traditional progress/development measures such as income. [ESS, FB539]

H_3 The relationship between quality of life (local amenities and disamenities) and domain satisfactions (life, place, personal, and financial) will differ across Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw pointing to local intricacies. [FB366,419]

5 Data, Measurement, and Methods

The goal is to do a comprehensive study of Polish geographies of wellbeing, hence we use multiple datasets, each having its own strengths: World Values Survey (WVS), European Social Survey (ESS), and Flash Barometers (FB): FB539 and FB366,419.

WVS has a usual SWB item: "All things considered, how satisfied are you with your life as a whole these days?" on scale 1-10. Such SWB measures tend to be reasonably valid and reliable (Diener 2009, ch. 5). WVS allows us to examine the geographies of wellbeing since 1989, which is important as Poland has evolved greatly. We have 4k observations, about 1k per wave.[14] Also, an important advantage of WVS is that urbanicity is recorded by an interviewer.[15]

[13] WVS=World Values Survey; ESS=European Social Survey; FB539=Flash Barometer #539–these and other datasets are described in the next section.

[14] We use waves 1989, 1997, 2005, and 2012. For the 1997, 2005, and 2012 waves we have 8 rural-urban categories -2k, 2-5k, 5-10k, 10-20k, 20-50k, 50-100k, 100-500k, and 500k-. In 1989 we only have information about 49 voivodeships, but urbanicity can be inferred from this information indirectly, and proximity to a major city directly.

[15] It is more objective than subjective respondent self-reports. For instance, respondents may not know well whether they live in a 20k or 30k place.

Freedom is measured in WVS,[16] and in some ESS waves containing a whole battery of wellbeing items measuring functionings and vitality. Preliminary analyses using ESS 1-6 cumulative file already had over 10k observations for Poland.[17] We will use ESS items such as those in wave 6 on functioning "free to decide how to live my life," and vitality "had lot of energy."[18]

FB539 (2024) has 5.2k observations and is representative of 17 NUTS2 regions, and has a usual SWB question similar to WVS.[19] FB366,419 (2012, 2015) are representative of 4 Polish cities: Bialystok, Gdansk, Cracow, and Warsaw. The sample size is about 2000 observations per wave, and again we have a usual SWB question like in WVS.

Data harmonization is not needed in WVS–one advantage of the survey is consistent measurement over time. We will use the data file that has all the waves in it with consistent coding of the variables. FB539 is a cross section. FB366,419 are 2 repeated cross sections (2012, 2015)–we will check coding of the survey items and if they differ and if we make over time comparisons using these data, we will harmonize. The same pertains to ESS. Specifically, some harmonization probably will be necessary for hypothesis H_1b as we will be using 2 different datasets WVS and EVS with different coding of the variables.

5.1 Models

We will mostly use ordinary least squares (OLS).[20] For robustness/sensitivity checks for the key models we will use multinomial logit (as the ordinal logit tends to fail proportional odds assumption). As another robustness/sensitivity check we are considering machine learning models such as gradient boosting models (Oparina et al. 2025), specifically XGBoost (`https://xgboost.readthedocs.io`). A key robustness/sensitivity check will be specification curve analysis (SCA) (Simonsohn et al. 2020).

We will use a usual set of controls such as those in the literature: for life satisfaction (e.g., Berry and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2009, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2010); and for freedom (e.g., Pitlik 2016, Nikolaev and Bennett 2016). And we will pay extra attention to the choice of control variables and avoid overcontrol bias, thus some of the controls used earlier in the literature may need to be reconsidered.[21]

We will combine some measures into indices using factor analysis paying attention to rotation (e.g., promax v varimax) (D'Italia and Okulicz-Kozaryn 2025) and Cronbach's alpha.

To examine geographic patterns among regions we will use choropleth maps, Moran's I, and Local Indicators of Spatial Association (LISA) (Anselin 1995).[22]

[16] "Some people feel they have completely free choice and control over their lives, while other people feel that what they do has no real effect on what happens to them. Please use this scale where 1 means 'none at all' and 10 means 'a great deal' to indicate how much freedom of choice and control you feel you have over the way your life turns out." Validity and reliability of the measure seem fine and the variable has been used successfully in the literature (e.g., Verme 2009, Inglehart et al. 2008, Veenhoven 2000a, Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014a).

[17] The data will be updated upto wave 12 that will be available in 2027.

[18] ESS urbanicity is measured with: a big city, suburbs or outskirts of big city, town or small city, country village, farm or home in countryside. Per wellbeing see overview at `https://www.europeansocialsurvey.org/findings/europeans-wellbeing/measuring-wellbeing`, and wave 6 wellbeing items: `https://europeansocialsurvey.org/sites/default/files/2026-01/ESS12-wellbeing-module-design-template.pdf` see Table 1: Items from the wellbeing module grouped by the dimension of wellbeing they relate to. We also will use new wave 12 that will be available in 2027 and will contain a wellbeing module. See `https://europeansocialsurvey.org/sites/default/files/2026-01/ESS12-wellbeing-module-design-template.pdf`.

[19] We may also use the earlier flash barometers: #497 (2021), #472 (2018), #427 (2015), #356 (2012) depending on how strong and robust the latest wave results are.

[20] Although OLS assumes cardinality of the outcome variable, and SWB measures are technically ordinal, OLS is an appropriate estimation method. Ferrer-i-Carbonell and Frijters (2004) has shown that OLS results are substantially the same as those from discrete models, and OLS has become the default method in happiness research (Blanchflower and Oswald 2011). Theoretically, while there is still debate about the cardinality of SWB, there are strong arguments to treat it as a cardinal variable (Ng 1996, 1997, 2011).

[21] "What we really need, to identify/estimate X$->$Y, is to control for other determinants of Y that are also antecedents of X (so, W$->$X). If we include controls where the relationship goes the other way (X$->$W), we will exacerbate bias in our estimate of X$->$Y. (The relevant term for that situation is 'overcontrol bias')" (Bartram et al. 2024, p. 5).

[22] We may do some multilevel modeling (MLM) at NUTS2 level as in Weckroth and Kemppainen (2021) but focusing on Poland. Yet MLM is problematic with only 17 U/As at Level 2–if we use it, results will be postponed to appendix. We may use Small Area Estimation (Moretti and Ahmed 2024).

6 Significance, Policy, and Practice

The proposed research will contribute to the literature and produce new knowledge. We will write at least 4 peer-reviewed articles[23] in this project, and through further research mentoring and leadership additional ones in the long term (see section "3.15. Didactic/mentoring activities" in the application form). Regarding the activities during the duration of this project see the next section.

The research also has policy and practical implications. There are many avenues for specific policy and practice collaborations. First, as stated in the introduction, the time has come for Poles to focus on wellbeing as opposed to just survival. Poland has modernized infrastructure, higher incomes, and booming economy. The focus on survival and economy can now give a way to wellbeing and flourishing. With the proposed study we aim to aid in this pursuit of happiness. It is relatively straightforward to implement the study's findings. For instance, we will find where and which social groups flourish and languish–such information can be then used to advance utilitarianism, produce the "greatest happiness for the greatest number" (Akay et al. 2015, Nussbaum 2012, Kahneman et al. 1997).

This is called evidence-based pursuit of happiness in the literature (Veenhoven 2012).[24] The proposed study will find out which parts of Poland enjoy high wellbeing and for whom–which social groups, e.g., by age and social class, flourish where? For instance, it may be the young and the educated that do not suffer from urban SWB penalty (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2014b). Our findings should help Poles increase their wellbeing.

One simple implementation is to educate policy makers, public administrators, and citizenry about the wellbeing metrics and study's findings so that we can make more informed decisions. To that end we will share and popularize our findings through public lectures, popular press, and social media. In the long term we are thinking about establishing a wellbeing research center in Poland, similar to Erasmus Happiness Economics Research Organisation (EHERO; `https://www.eur.nl/ehero`), where PI used to work. Long term (after this project) it could be data collection, say implementing a survey similar to Flash Barometers locally; or using social media data to measure wellbeing (Iacus et al. 2025).

SWB can and should be used for public policy and administration (Diener 2009). SWB can serve as a "yardstick" (Veenhoven 1988)–arguably the ultimate outcome of public policy and administration is SWB.[25] "If you can't measure it, you can't improve it"–if governments don't measure wellbeing, they can't improve wellbeing. I will reach out to Polish government to implement the study findings in practice. I plan to start locally with Wielkopolska voivodeship, where I will be physically carrying out the study, and other regional governments may be involved as well. Likewise, some city governments may be involved as the study will use data representative of 4 cities.

Another avenue is to use the wellbeing metrics to evaluate policy. For instance, if there is a major change in policy or investment in public goods, we can actually measure whether it produced an increase in wellbeing by using before-after comparative group research design (difference-in-difference). We could use a SWB yardstick to measure policy effectiveness in terms of SWB. We will try to identify specific local tractable problems and interventions when we start the project, but for the sake of illustrative example only let's use here a major national problem, income inequality and solution, progressive taxation–see figure 3. Let's assume that progressive taxation worked and we achieved relative income equality. And we usually stop there, but we should probe further–have we improved human lot, did we improve quality of life, has wellbeing increased? Usually the outcome of interest is only worthwhile if it leads to the ultimate outcome of interest, SWB[26] (Okulicz-Kozaryn 2016).

[23] Out of which at least 3 published in major international journals such as Social Indicators Research, Applied Research in Quality of Life, and Cities, with IF>3.

[24] There is a psychological nuance here–one should not focus fully on the pursuit of happiness and chase it or value it intensely (Mauss et al. 2011, Gruber et al. 2011), neither be concerned about it and judge it (Zerwas et al. 2024)–it may backfire. Rather, one needs to know what is important for wellbeing from the academic literature, like the proposed study, and include this information in everyday decision-making. For instance, humans should buy experience such as travel and time with others, not things such as conspicuous consumption items (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Tursi 2015, Veblen 2005a,b, Thoreau 1995 [1854]).

[25] While the idea of using wellbeing data for policy and administration is new in Poland, it is not new in general (Stiglitz et al. 2009, Diener 2009).

[26] There are few exceptions to this rule, and SWB is not the only outcome of interest especially in the short run, indeed, we may often need to sacrifice SWB in the short run in order to achieve it in the long run–for instance save, invest, postpone consumption, and work hard in order to increase SWB later.

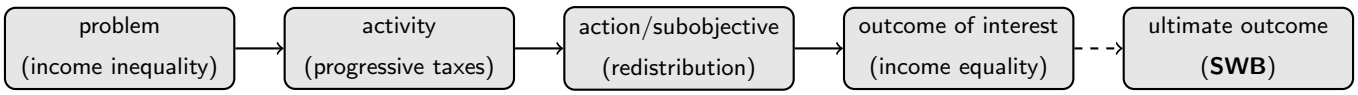


Figure 3: An outcome line. Usually we stop at outcome of interest. Yet the outcome of interest is only of value (with few exceptions) if it results in ultimate outcome of interest, SWB.

One avenue would be to engage with energy policy. While in general energy use has been found to be unrelated to SWB earlier (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Altman 2019), this claim needs to be re-examined amidst current energy crisis and skyrocketing prices. Massive reductions in consumption and altering of the lifestyles may ultimately reduce wellbeing.

In framing policy and practice discussion we will also use Latin American perspective. One of the team members is a senior wellbeing scholar from Latin America, a public policy researcher whose work integrates the analysis of social programs, impact evaluation, and subjective well-being metrics. Our expert has also practical experience–has served as a consultant for the World Bank and the Inter-American Development Bank in Latin America. Latin America is the happiest region in the World (Rojas 2015, 2025), and while there are similarities between Poland and Latin America, such as high levels of social connection, there are specific actionable lessons from Latin America that other countries can use, including Poland (Okulicz-Kozaryn and Martinez 2025).

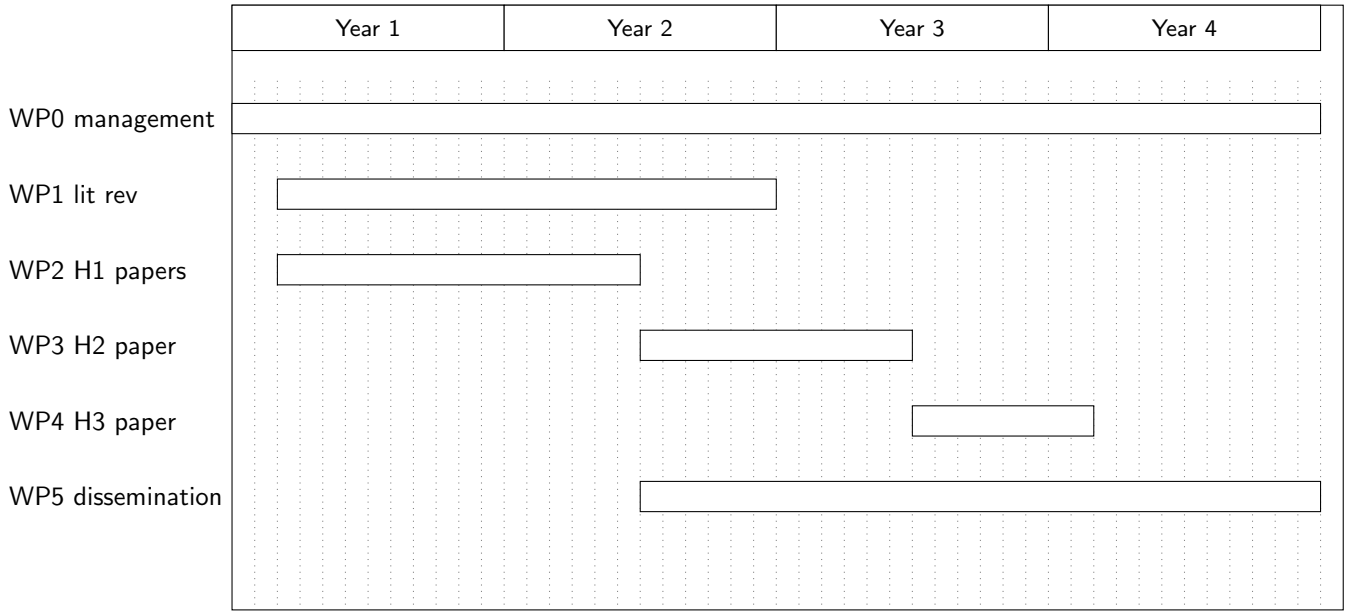
7 Research Plan: Work Packages (WPs); and Work Plan: Key Milestones (KMs)

Note: in square brackets are enumerated team members responsible for each task; order indicates workload from high to low:

- all=all team members
- aok=adam okulicz kozaryn (principal investigator)
- lm=lina marinez
- em=ebshoy mikhaeil
- mb=mariusz baranowski
- pj=piotr jablkowski
- pc=piotr cichocki
- student= AMU (Adam Mickiewicz University) graduate student; there are 3 of them
- WP0 months 0-48: management [aok]
  - T0 months 0-48 management: project management and coordination notably tracking the timeline and managing progress, communication, and risks [aok]
  - T1 months 0-2 meet and greet: conduct a series of in-person and zoom meetings to plan and get going with the project [all]
  - T2 months 0-2 setup project: complete necessary paperwork, notably employ team members at the university [all]; note: IRB approval is not necessary as we are using secondary data only
  - T3 months 0-48 meetings: in-person (whenever possible) or zoom (if necessary) weekly or at very least every two weeks meetings of team members currently involved in project tasks with PI [aok, team members currently working on tasks]
  - T4 months 45-48 report and finalize: write final report and finalize the project [aok,lm,em]
- KM0A month2: setup done KM0B month48: project finalized and final report done
- WP1 months 2-24: literature review[27]
  - T1 literature review: assign literature domains to 2 AMU students, and have students perform the review [2students]
  - T2 literature review supervision: have more senior team members supervise the students and hold periodic meetings at least every 2 weeks or as necessary [em,aok]
  - T3 finalize literature reviews: draft and revise literature reviews for subsequent 4-5 journal articles [2students,em,aok]

[27] Note: literature review is the key part of the study–going back to the classic sociologists of the 19th and 20th century to motivate measurement is the key part of out conceptual framework.

- KM1 month12: literature review done
- WP2 months 2-18 H1 papers: data management, analysis, and 2-3 papers drafting for hypothesis H1
  - T1 data management: clean, organize, document, recode [em,1student,aok]
  - T2 exploratory data analysis: descriptive statistics and visualizations [em,1student,aok]
  - T3 main analyses: mostly regressions and robustness checks (see for details methods section) [em,aok,1student]
  - T4 analysis review and revisions: review and revisions of the analyses by the senior team members [aok,pc,mb,pj]
  - T5 paper drafting and revisions: drafting of the papers and revisions [aok,lm,em,2students]
- KM2 month18: data analyzed and 2-3 papers drafted for H1
- WP3 months 18-30 H2 paper: data management, analysis, and 1 paper drafting for hypothesis H2; Tasks are the same as in WP2
- KM3 month30: data analyzed and 1 paper drafted for H2
- WP4 months 30-38 H3 paper: data management, analysis, and 1 paper drafting for hypothesis H3; Tasks are the same as in WP2
- KM4 month38: data analyzed and 1 paper drafted for H3
- WP5 months 18-48 dissemination: academic dissemination, real-world popularization, and policy engagement
  - T1 articles: $>=$ 3 submissions to journals with $IF > 3$ such as `Applied Research in Quality of Life`, `Social Indicators Research`, or `Cities` [all]
  - T2 conferences: 3 conference presentations such as `International Society for Quality-of-Life Studies (ISQOLS)` or `European Regional Science Association (ERSA)` [aok,lm,em]
  - T3 lectures: $>=$4 public lectures and or seminars at AMU and or other Polish universities
  - T4 policy engagement: engage with local public policy and administration starting in Poznan and Wielkopolska [aok,1student]
  - T5 popularization: popularization via popular media (e.g., Glos Wielkopolski) and or social media (e.g., YouTube) [aok,lm,em,1stude
- KM5 month48: dissemination and popularization done



8 Risks

see application form "3.9. Risk analysis and security issues"

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